SHOWING THE WAY Anjani Kumar Singh with chief minister Nitish Kumar at the Bihar Museum Biennale 2025, Patna, Aug. 7

"The Bihar Museum was built with these requirements in mind, and this has opened doors," he says. "We've sent exhibitions to the Metropolitan Museum in New York, the Rijksmuseum in Amsterdam, Kazakhstan and Guyana, and planning more."

Singh values quality over quantity in collaborations. "A successful MoU means real exchange: artists visiting, workshops, exhibitions travelling both ways," he says. Despite challenges like high art-handling costs, he believes ongoing partnerships will build the trust needed for lasting cooperation. The biennale's 2025 logo embodies this spirit. Inspired by the 'Tree of Life,' it blends Africa's baobab, India's peepal leaf and South America's Otomi and Lliclla patterns. "If a logo needs a long explanation, it's not effective. This one instantly reflects our shared heritage," explains Singh.

As it grows in scale and influence, the Bihar Museum Biennale challenges assumptions about what museums are and what they can become. "I believe that, over time, the biennale will influence museological practice worldwide," Singh concludes. "By fostering greater inclusivity, representation and collaboration among museums that have historically been under-represented, we can create a more equitable cultural dialogue." In doing so, Bihar Museum Biennale 2025 doesn't just showcase the world; it helps shape its future. ■

—Nikhil Sardana

CLASSICAL ▼

Of Timeless Grace

Bharatanatyam exponent Dr Padma Subrahmanyam brings the fluidity and symbolism of temple sculptures to the dance stage

She meditates silently, relaxes physically and mentally. Padma Vibhushan Dr Padma Subrahmanyam readies herself for a Bharatanatyam performance with this practice. In her 80s now, this iconic figure in Indian classical dance has long been celebrated as a pioneering scholar who reshaped how the world views Bharatanatyam.

At a time when dance was confined to stage performance, Dr Subrahmanyam did a Master's in ethnomusicology, later earning a PhD for groundbreaking work on the *karanas*, dance movements described in Natyashastra. Through years of painstaking study, she reconstructed 108 *karanas*, restoring a bridge between temple sculpture and live dance. On August 22, audiences at the National Centre for Performing Arts, Mumbai, will get to witness the *Bhagavad Gita*, a dance drama choreographed and performed by the danseuse. She says, "The goal and the soul of this performance is to communicate to the audience the content of this great work. It is very abstract, so it was a challenge to concretise those abstract concepts." Set in the Bhanika style that blends dance with mono-acting, the performance draws from all 18 chapters across four thematic sequences in which 78 original Sanskrit shlokas have been incorporated.

Born in 1943, Padma describes how her inspiration from temple sculptures for choreography started. "I was in my late teens when I ventured into choreographing a dance drama—Meenakshi Kalyanam. Maybe I was too young to realise the importance of what I was doing." Dr Subrahmanyam, who through her Nrithyodaya School in Chennai has mentored generations of dancers, feels gratified that her work finds resonance across audiences. "A few months back, when I did *Bhagavad Gita* in Chennai, there was a huge crowd, and many were young dancers. They were shedding tears of joy, and it seemed they understood everything that I had danced. I believe that the art of *abhinaya* means communication, and if there is communication, it will reach all age groups and all strata of society," she says. ■

—Priya Pathiyan



THE DANCE DRAMA *BHAGAVAD GITA* IS SET IN THE *BHANIKA* STYLE THAT BLENDS DANCE WITH MONO-ACTING